top of the boundary wall was rounded and for someone who had just learnt to balance herself on a flat surface, balancing here was out of the question. As a result, my attempt to sit on top of the wall failed and I fell, face down. But it was not for nothing—while still mid-air, I had caught a quick glimpse of a small brown puppy crying from under a heap of dry leaves. The mystery had been solved. The next moment, I landed on the heap of dry leaves and branches. A terrible pinching pain below my frock made me cry out loud. It was the thorns. But then, I felt something moist and wet on the side of my face. The little puppy was licking my cheek. I giggled. But then I cried again. Confused, I didn't know what to do. It was joy and pain at the same time.

The next thing I remember is the silhouette of a woman running towards me. 'Gunjan . . . Gunjan . . . Are you okay? Look, mummy is here.' It was Maa who picked me up in her arms. She had been terrified at first and had quickly scanned my body for any signs of injury. The heap of leaves had softened the impact. Rescued, I stopped crying. Relieved that I had not broken anything, Maa stopped panicking.

'It's just some scratches, Gunju. You're a strong baby, aren't you?' she said, reassuring herself more than me. She held me tightly against her chest and sighed. The puppy had hidden himself inside the heap of leaves on seeing Maa. As she got up with me in her arms and started to walk away, I started to cry again. 'Naa . . . naa,' I screamed and struggled in her arms.

'What is it, baby?' she stopped and asked. After a pause, I pointed at the heap of leaves and it was then that she saw the puppy for the first time.

'Doggy?' a confused Maa said.

I nodded. 'You came for the doggy?' she said. I nodded again. For a moment she looked at the puppy, and then at me. 'Umm . . . his mama will come and take him. Let's go now.' No sooner had she said this than I launched into incessant sobs. 'Hey! Ssshhh. *Beta*, what happened?' She began to wipe my tears. The puppy, too, let out squeals in unison. I raised my hand towards the sky and she could see that I was pointing at the dark clouds. 'Oh, Gunjan!' she said as she realized what I meant. 'You don't want the doggy to get wet! Okay, let's take him inside. Will you stop crying